UNIT 6

Frequent irregular verbs, infinitives, and commands

This unit adds frequent irregular indicative systems, commands addressed to one or more people, and infinitives used after modals or to express purpose.

In the tables, **1**, **2**, and **3** mean first, second, and third person; **sg.** and **pl.** mean singular and plural. **1–3 pl.** gives the same form for all three plural persons. Dual subjects take plural finite verbs. Preserve vowel length and the distinction between e and ę. Examples and exercises are new teaching material unless a source is explicitly identified.

1. Words and meanings

The verb labels in the first column identify systems. Some are conventional dictionary labels rather than usable infinitives; §2 explains the distinction. Learn the meanings given here with their stated constructions.

Word or verb label	Meaning in this unit	Construction
witan	know	accusative fact or matter known
cunnan	know how; be able through skill	plain infinitive
ðurfan	need to	plain infinitive
durran	dare to	plain infinitive
sculan	must; be obliged to	plain infinitive
mugan, also called magan	can; be able to	plain infinitive
mōtan	may; be allowed to	plain infinitive
willan	wish; want to	plain infinitive
dōn	do; perform	accusative work or thing done
gān	go; walk	ordinary intransitive use
ðing, neuter	thing; a fact or matter known	the earlier noun forms, with this additional meaning
tō	to	before an inflected infinitive

The new sense of **ðing** includes a matter known or discussed. It does not replace the earlier sense of a thing or object. No new noun declension is

needed. Infinitival tō is distinguished from locally supplied destination phrases in the source reading.

2. Complete indicative systems

Preterite-present verbs

These verbs have present forms inherited from an older strong preterite. Thus **wāt** and **cann** resemble strong past forms but have present meaning. Their own preterites have a dental element, as weak preterites do. The historical name **preterite-present** does not make their present tense past in translation.

The first and third singular present coincide. The second singular has its own form, and all three plural persons share another. Learn the singular/plural stem changes and the dental preterite together.

Present indicative.

Person and number	witan	cunnan	ðurfan	durran
1 sg.	wāt	cann	ðearf	dearr
2 sg.	wāst	canst	ðearft	dearst
3 sg.	wāt	cann	ðearf	dearr
1–3 pl.	witon	cunnon	ðurfon	durron

Person and number	sculan	mugan	mōtan
1 sg.	sceal	mæg	mōt
2 sg.	scealt	meaht	mōst
3 sg.	sceal	mæg	mōt
1–3 pl.	sculon	magon	mōton

Preterite indicative.

Person and number	witan	cunnan	ðurfan	durran
1 sg.	wiste	cūðe	ðorfte	dorste
2 sg.	wistest	cūðest	ðorftest	dorstest
3 sg.	wiste	cūðe	ðorfte	dorste
1–3 pl.	wiston	cūðon	ðorfton	dorston

Person and number	sculan	mugan	mōtan
1 sg.	sceolde	meahte	mōste
2 sg.	sceoldest	meahtest	mōstest
3 sg.	sceolde	meahte	mōste
1–3 pl.	sceoldon	meahton	mōston

For each verb, the present and preterite tables give all twelve person–number–tense cells. In the preterite, the first and third singular end in **-e**; the second singular adds **-st**, and the plural changes **-e** to **-on**. Keep each verb's printed stem. The second singular here does not follow the strong-preterite pattern learned in Units 4–5.

Selected forms and alternatives. This course selects witan, witon, and wiste. Wieton/wioton and the wisse-series are documented alternatives. Cook also gives can beside cann and scolde beside sceolde. For mugan, the tables select meaht and meahte; Wright records miht and mehte/mihte. Use the selected forms when an exercise asks for them; the alternatives are not errors merely because they differ.

Citation labels and missing forms. Cook's **mugan** and the common label **magan** name the same system. Fulk marks the conventional infinitives *durran, *sculan, *mōtan, and *magan as unattested. Cook marks several labels as doubtful. A label ending in -an is therefore not sufficient evidence for an infinitive that can be put into a sentence. Do not make an inflected infinitive or a command by adding ordinary endings to these labels.

The labels witan, cunnan, and ðurfan are attested uninflected infinitives, but their infinitival uses and complete command systems are not taught here. Learn the finite systems above and the selected infinitive pairs below. A missing cell is different from two genuine cells that happen to share a spelling, such as the first and third singular wāt.

Cook and Wright call certain witan forms commands; Fulk describes such preterite-present command uses as subjunctive substitutes. They do not establish an ordinary imperative pair for every modal. These substitutes and first- or third-person wishes are outside this unit's command practice.

Sources. Albert S. Cook, **A First Book in Old English: Grammar, Reader, Notes, and Vocabulary**, second edition (1895), §§125–137, pp.76–78 / PDF pp.92–94. R. D. Fulk, **An Introductory Grammar of Old English with an Anthology of Readings**, corrected 2020 reprint, §123, pp.89–90 / PDF pp.101–102, distinguishes unattested labels and command substitutes. Joseph and Elizabeth Mary Wright, **Old English Grammar**, second edition (1914), gives the corroborating witan and magan variants; see the precise variant references in §9.

Dōn, gān, and willan

Learn each present with its preterite. **Dōn** changes ō to ē in dēst and dēð, and has the past dyde. **Gān** changes ā to æ in gǣst and gǣð; its past **ēode** comes from a different stem. **Willan** has wille in both the first and third singular present, with wilt in the second singular. Do not add an ordinary third-singular -ð to wille.

Present indicative.

Person and number	dōn	gān	willan
1 sg.	dō	gā	wille
2 sg.	dēst	gǣst	wilt
3 sg.	dēð	gǣð	wille
1–3 pl.	dōð	gāð	willað

Preterite indicative.

Person and number	dōn	gān	willan
1 sg.	dyde	ēode	wolde
2 sg.	dydest	ēodest	woldest
3 sg.	dyde	ēode	wolde
1–3 pl.	dydon	ēodon	woldon

Cook also gives **wile** beside wille. The table selects the spelling with double l. The negative contracted companions are not additional paradigms to learn in this unit.

Sources. Cook §§138–141, pp.78–80 / PDF pp.94–96. Fulk §134, p.102 / PDF p.114, corroborates the complete dōn, gān, and willan indicative systems.

The alternative bēo present

The following alternative present series belongs with the earlier verb "be." Both present series share the familiar preterite: wæs in the first and third singular, wǣre in the second singular, and wǣron in all plural persons. There is no separate bēon past to construct.

Person and number	Earlier eom series	Alternative bēo series
1 sg.	eom	bēo
2 sg.	eart	bist
3 sg.	is	bið
1–3 pl.	sindon	bēoð

The bēo series can describe an expected later state. The predicate still follows the agreement already learned. In the following example the ship's readiness is expected later.

Đæt scip bið gearu.

The ship will be ready, in an explicitly expected later situation.

Bēo forms also occur with habitual or general truths. Context matters: the two present series are not an absolute division into "now" and "future," and every bið need not be translated "will be." The exercises here give an explicit expected-later context.

Sources. Cook §138, pp.78–79 / PDF pp.94–95; Fulk §52, p.33 / PDF p.45.

Practice A. Indicative systems and citation labels

A1.
Give all six person-and-number cells of the present indicative and all six of the preterite indicative of witan. Use the selected course forms and label every cell even where spellings coincide.

A2.
Give all six person-and-number cells of the present indicative and all six of the preterite indicative of cunnan. Use the selected course forms and label every cell even where spellings coincide.

A3.
Give all six person-and-number cells of the present indicative and all six of the preterite indicative of ðurfan. Use the selected course forms and label every cell even where spellings coincide.

A4.
Give all six person-and-number cells of the present indicative and all six of the preterite indicative of durran. Use the selected course forms and label every cell even where spellings coincide.

A5.
Give all six person-and-number cells of the present indicative and all six of the preterite indicative of sculan. Use the selected course forms and label every cell even where spellings coincide.

A6.
Give all six person-and-number cells of the present indicative and all six of the preterite indicative of mugan. Use the selected course forms and label every cell even where spellings coincide.

A7.
Give all six person-and-number cells of the present indicative and all six of the preterite indicative of mōtan. Use the selected course forms and label every cell even where spellings coincide.

A8.
Give all six person-and-number cells of the present indicative and all six of the preterite indicative of dōn. Use the selected course forms and label every cell even where spellings coincide.

A9.
Give all six person-and-number cells of the present indicative and all six of the preterite indicative of gān. Use the selected course forms and label every cell even where spellings coincide.

A10.
Give all six person-and-number cells of the present indicative and all six of the preterite indicative of willan. Use the selected course forms and label every cell even where spellings coincide.

A11.
Give all six person-and-number cells of the bēo present indicative series. Then give the corresponding earlier eom series. Does bēo supply a separate past-tense paradigm?

A12.
Compare wāt and wiste; cann and cūðe; gǣð and ēode; dēð and dyde. Using a third-person singular subject, identify the tense of each. Which forms can also serve a first-person singular subject? Explain why wāt and cann are not translated as past-tense forms.

A13.
The reference notes mark some modal infinitive citations as unattested or uncertain. Explain why a dictionary label such as mugan does not authorize you to create an infinitive or a command for every modal verb. Distinguish a missing paradigm cell from two attested cells with the same spelling.

3. Infinitives and their uses

An **infinitive** names an action without marking person or number. The **plain infinitive** normally ends in -an or -ian, with contracted forms such as gān and dōn. In earlier units many infinitives were printed only to name verbs. The forms in this unit's tables are now learned for the stated uses.

The **inflected infinitive** follows the separate word **tō**. For the selected -an forms, replace -an with **-anne**; -ian consequently gives **-ianne**. Keep the stem consonants: doubled consonants remain doubled in the inflected infinitive. Contracted forms ending in -n add -ne, giving **-nne**: the complete forms appear in §4. The infinitive is not conjugated for the subject's person or number.

The tables select **-anne**. **-enne** is also a documented ending; it is a valid variant, although an exercise expressly requesting the selected -anne form still asks for that form. Infinitive formation does not supply missing modal forms or teach participles, perfects, or passives.

A finite modal with a plain infinitive

In the constructions below, the finite verb agrees with the subject and marks present or past. The plain infinitive expresses the action performed by that same subject. It takes neither personal endings nor tō in this construction. Two or more people, including a dual-pronoun subject, take a plural finite verb; the infinitive itself stays unchanged.

Cunnan expresses knowing how through learning or skill. **Mugan** expresses capability: the subject is able to perform the action. English "can" can represent either, so select the intended sense from the context.

Ic cann swimman. Hē mæg ðæt wæter beran.

I know how to swim. He can carry the water.

For the skill statements, learn these additional infinitive pairs. No imperative pair for either verb is required here.

Verb	Plain infinitive	Inflected infinitive after tō
singan	singan	singanne
swimman	swimman	swimmanne

Đurfan expresses need to do something; **durran**, daring to do it. **Sculan** expresses obligation or necessity in the selected use. **Mōtan** expresses permission, "be allowed to." A past form can describe actual past need, daring, obligation, or permission: the morphology alone does not make the statement hypothetical.

In particular, selected **mōste** can mean "was allowed to"; it need not mean modern English "must." Other senses occur in the language, but the exercises state the sense required here.

Wē sculon ðæt weorc gefręmman.

We must perform the work.

Willan expresses wishing or wanting. Its preterite **wolde** can state past desire. **Faran** is used intransitively for going or travelling; it can name the desired action without an expressed object or destination.

Hē wolde faran.

He wanted to travel.

Wanting to travel does not by itself assert that the journey occurred. Do not translate every wolde as hypothetical "would," or treat willan as an automatic future-tense auxiliary.

The familiar negative **ne** precedes the finite verb. Use this ordinary pattern with the selected durran and mugan clauses. Contracted negative paradigms and negative concord are not needed.

Witan with a noun object

Witan, "know," takes an accusative nominal object for the matter known. The following "things" are facts or matters already discussed. The noun's form is familiar; its fact/matter meaning is new here.

Ic wāt ðā ðing.

I know those things, referring to matters already discussed.

This is knowledge of something, whereas cunnan with an infinitive describes knowing how to do something. The object here is a noun phrase; no finite "that" clause is required.

Ordinary action and purpose

Use **dōn**, "do; perform," with an accusative work or thing done. Use **gān**, "go," and **cuman**, "come," in ordinary intransitive clauses. These uses do not require a destination phrase and do not establish a general rule for motion prepositions.

After **cuman**, **tō + inflected infinitive** can state the purpose of coming. The person or people who come are also the understood performers of the infinitive's action.

Hē cōm tō helpanne.

He came to help.

Here he came, and he intended to help. The infinitive names the purpose; it does not assert that the helping was completed. This is the purpose construction practised below. Old English also permits certain bare infinitives after motion verbs, so it would be wrong to say that every grammatical purpose must have tō. When an exercise requests the inflected construction, provide that target.

An infinitive keeps the object relations of its verb. Carrying, taking, and eating can have accusative objects; **helpan** takes the person helped in the dative. Giving has an accusative thing and a dative recipient. Adding a modal or changing to an inflected infinitive does not turn those datives into accusatives.

Sources. Cook §§199–200, pp.105–106 / PDF pp.121–122; Fulk §58, p.38 / PDF p.50. Cook §200 provides cuman with an inflected purpose infinitive; §199.1 also records bare infinitives with motion and purpose. The modal distinctions follow **Bosworth–Toller, An Anglo-Saxon Dictionary**, main dictionary (1898): CUNNAN II, p.174b; MAGAN III(1), p.665a; ÞURFAN II(1), p.1076b; DURRAN, p.219b; SCULAN II(1), pp.843b–844; MÓTAN I, p.699a–b; WILLAN II(a), p.1226b. Ordinary DÓN is at p.208b, GÁN at p.360b, and FARAN I at p.270b. Witan's nominal object is evidenced in Cook Reader XII, p.173 / PDF p.189; the known-fact sense of þing appears under WITAN I(6)(a), Bosworth–Toller p.1244b. Cuman is glossed in Cook's vocabulary, p.282 / PDF p.298.

4. Commands and complete model tables

The **imperative** directly addresses the person who is to act. Use the second singular for one addressee and the second plural for two or more. There is no separate dual imperative ending. The subject may be omitted; an expressed subject can precede the verb. The commands used here omit it unless the exercise states otherwise.

Nim ðone męte. Nimað ðone męte.

Take the food, one addressee. Take the food, several addressees.

The number of the command identifies the addressees, not the number of its object. A command concerning the same food may address one person or several.

The following tables give each complete command pair beside its complete plain/inflected infinitive pair. **The last column is used after separate tō.** Learn every form printed here. Most plural commands match the present indicative plural; that shared spelling does not make their uses identical.

Weak I

The heavy-stem model has no final -e in the singular command: **hīer**. The short and geminate patterns have **-e**, with the singular consonant pattern shown in **sęle, sęte, gefręme, nęre**. In nęre the i of nęrian is absent; it remains in the plural nęriað. **Gierwan** has **giere**, without w, beside gierwað.

Learn **cys** and **gefyl** with a single final consonant, beside cyssað and gefyllað. Their selected final simplification does not turn them into the -e type. Conversely, sęttan has sęte; its double consonant is not a reason to use the cys pattern. Final consonant simplification is frequent, not a claim that all unsimplified final spellings are impossible.

Verb	Command to one	Command to two or more	Plain infinitive	Inflected infinitive after tō
sęllan	sęle	sęllað	sęllan	sęllanne
hīeran	hīer	hīerað	hīeran	hīeranne
gefyllan	gefyl	gefyllað	gefyllan	gefyllanne
cyssan	cys	cyssað	cyssan	cyssanne
sęttan	sęte	sęttað	sęttan	sęttanne
gierwan	giere	gierwað	gierwan	gierwanne
gefręmman	gefręme	gefręmmað	gefręmman	gefręmmanne
nęrian	nęre	nęriað	nęrian	nęrianne

Weak II and III

Weak II changes **-ian** to **-a** for the singular command and retains **-iað** in the plural: lufa/lufiað. Its inflected infinitive has -ianne.

The four learned weak-III verbs require their own singular forms: **hafa, leofa, saga, hoga**. Their plural commands use the familiar present-plural stems. Form habbanne from habban; the command stem hafa is different.

Verb	Command to one	Command to two or more	Plain infinitive	Inflected infinitive after tō
lufian	lufa	lufiað	lufian	lufianne
habban	hafa	habbað	habban	habbanne
libban	leofa	libbað	libban	libbanne
sęcgan	saga	sęcgað	sęcgan	sęcganne
hycgan	hoga	hycgað	hycgan	hycganne

Cook also gives **sęge** beside saga and **lifiað** beside libbað, and optional e in **sęcg(e)að** and **hycg(e)að**. The tables select saga, libbað, sęcgað, and hycgað. The earlier recognition-only negative companion nabban receives no new command requirement.

Sources for the weak forms. Cook §§112–124, pp.68–76 / PDF pp.84–92. Final-geminate simplification is described in §35, pp.24–25 / PDF pp.40–41; cys and gefyl apply that rule to the heavy weak-I pattern, rather than being separate continuous-text quotations. Wright §§521–525 and 529–530, pp.266–268 and 270–271 / PDF pp.286–288 and 290–291, corroborates the short, geminate, and gierwan patterns.

Strong I–III

The ordinary singular command uses the present stem without the infinitive ending. Do not import the changed vowel of the indicative second or third singular into it. The ordinary plural command matches the present indicative plural.

Contracted verbs need a separate singular command in **-h**. Class I wrēon gives **wrīh**, with long ī; Class II tēon gives **tēoh**, with long ēo. Their plurals and infinitives stay contracted. In the table, drīfan and wrēon belong to Class I; bēodan and tēon to II; bindan, helpan, and drincan to III.

Verb	Command to one	Command to two or more	Plain infinitive	Inflected infinitive after tō
drīfan	drīf	drīfað	drīfan	drīfanne
wrēon	wrīh	wrēoð	wrēon	wrēonne
bēodan	bēod	bēodað	bēodan	bēodanne
tēon	tēoh	tēoð	tēon	tēonne
bindan	bind	bindað	bindan	bindanne
helpan	help	helpað	helpan	helpanne
drincan	drinc	drincað	drincan	drincanne

Strong IV–V

Beran, niman, and cuman are Class IV. The remaining verbs in this table are Class V. The ordinary singular **cum** retains u, unlike the changed indicative singular vowel.

The strong j-present verbs have singular commands in **-e**, like the short weak-I pattern: **bide, lige, site**. Gemination is absent in these singulars. Licgan has g in lige, beside cg in licgað. Contracted sēon has **seoh**, with short eo, beside long ēo in sēoð.

Verb	Command to one	Command to two or more	Plain infinitive	Inflected infinitive after tō
cuman	cum	cumað	cuman	cumanne
beran	ber	berað	beran	beranne
niman	nim	nimað	niman	nimanne
giefan	gief	giefað	giefan	giefanne
biddan	bide	biddað	biddan	biddanne
licgan	lige	licgað	licgan	licganne
sittan	site	sittað	sittan	sittanne
etan	et	etað	etan	etanne
sēon	seoh	sēoð	sēon	sēonne

Strong VI–VII

Faran, standan, slēan, hębban, scieppan, and swęrian are Class VI. Hātan, healdan, weaxan, lǣtan, and fōn are Class VII.

The j-present singulars are **hęfe, sciepe, swęre**. Hębban changes bb to f in the singular command. Swęrian has swęre beside swęriað. Contracted slēan gives **sleah**, with short ea; fōn gives **fōh**, with long ō. Keep these quantities distinct from those in the corresponding infinitives.

Verb	Command to one	Command to two or more	Plain infinitive	Inflected infinitive after tō
hātan	hāt	hātað	hātan	hātanne
standan	stand	standað	standan	standanne
faran	far	farað	faran	faranne
slēan	sleah	slēað	slēan	slēanne
hębban	hęfe	hębbað	hębban	hębbanne
scieppan	sciepe	scieppað	scieppan	scieppanne
swęrian	swęre	swęriað	swęrian	swęrianne
healdan	heald	healdað	healdan	healdanne
weaxan	weax	weaxað	weaxan	weaxanne
lǣtan	lǣt	lǣtað	lǣtan	lǣtanne
fōn	fōh	fōð	fōn	fōnne

Sources for the strong forms. Cook §§93–95, pp.54–55 / PDF pp.70–71; §§100–101, pp.57–59 / PDF pp.73–75; §§106–107, pp.64–65 / PDF pp.80–81. Wright §§478 and 480, pp.250–251 / PDF pp.270–271, corroborates imperative endings and inflected infinitives. Fulk §127, pp.93–94 / PDF pp.105–106, corroborates the j-present singulars and their consonant alternations. Wrīh applies Cook's stated Class I contracted pattern to wrēon; the model-derived form is not presented as a separate prose quotation.

Dōn, gān, wesan, and bēon

Learn **dō/dōð**, **gā/gāð**, **wes/wesað**, and **bēo/bēoð** as complete pairs. Their contracted infinitives keep the contracted stem before -nne. Wesan has the ordinary -anne form.

These second-person commands are distinct from an indicative or a supplied third-person wish that may share a spelling. Neither willan nor the preterite-present verbs receives a regular command pair by analogy with them.

Verb	Command to one	Command to two or more	Plain infinitive	Inflected infinitive after tō
wesan	wes	wesað	wesan	wesanne
dōn	dō	dōð	dōn	dōnne
gān	gā	gāð	gān	gānne
bēon	bēo	bēoð	bēon	bēonne

Gā. Dō ðæt weorc wel.

Go. Do the work well, one addressee.

Some verbs remain form models for uses not yet learned. A full command or infinitive row does not by itself teach a new object, a causative complement, or a naming construction. Keep the earlier limits on such models as gierwan and hycgan, and on the complement uses of hātan, lǣtan, bēodan, and biddan.

Reference variant. Cook records a shortened plural **-e** immediately before a following subject pronoun. Use the full plural forms above when the subject is omitted or precedes the verb. The positional variant is supplied for reference here, not an additional free choice of ending or a first-/third-person command system.

Sources. Cook §§138–141, pp.78–80 / PDF pp.94–96; Fulk §134, p.102 / PDF p.114. The postposed-pronoun variant is Cook §95, p.55 / PDF p.71. Inflected -anne/-enne is also described by Wright §480, p.251 / PDF p.271, and Fulk §58, p.38 / PDF p.50.

Objects, negative commands, and quoted speech

Commands retain the verb's familiar government. Giving still has a dative recipient and an accusative thing; helpan still takes the dative person helped.

Gief mē ðæt wæter. Helpað mē.

Give me the water, one addressee. Help me, several addressees.

Put **ne** directly before the imperative for the simple negative command practised here.

Ne drinc ðæt wæter.

Do not drink the water, one addressee.

A quotation introduced by **cweðan** may now contain these direct commands. Within the quotation, "I," "me," and "you" belong to the speaker's and addressee's situation. The quotation is not an indirect command and does not require a new dependent mood.

Sources. Cook §198, p.105 / PDF p.121, gives commands with or without an expressed second-person subject. The negative imperative is directly evidenced in Reader XII, p.183 / PDF p.199, editorial line 7, and quoted in §§156h and 159a, pp.92–93 / PDF pp.108–109. These citations support the construction; their additional vocabulary is not needed for the exercises.

5. Practice in clauses and forms

All exercises are new teaching material. Unless an exercise asks for a supplied reference, use the forms and constructions learned in this and earlier units. Preserve the stated modal sense. When a particular course form or construction is requested, distinguish that target from another valid expression.

Practice M. Meanings and infinitive complements

M1.
Translate “I know how to swim. We know how to sing.” Use cunnan for learned ability.

M2.
Translate “He can carry the water. They can help the man.” Use mugan for ability.

M3.
Translate “I need to go. We needed to go.” Use ðurfan.

M4.
Translate “You dare to go. You dared to go.” Address one person and use durran.

M5.
Translate “We must do the work. They had to do the work.” Use sculan for obligation.

M6.
Translate “You are allowed to eat the food. You were allowed to eat the food.” Address one person and use mōtan.

M7.
Translate “He wants to give the birds water. They wanted to give the birds water.” Use willan for desire.

M8.
Translate “I did not dare to go. We cannot carry the ship.” Use the taught simple ne construction.

M9.
Translate “We two know how to swim. You two must help us two.” Keep the two-person references.

M10.
Translate “He wanted to go. He went.” Explain why the first sentence alone does not assert that he went.

M11.
Translate the printed pairs Ic cann swimman and Ic mæg swimman using the unit's stated difference between learned ability and present capability. Identify the finite verb and the infinitive in each. Do not claim that one English word always represents only one Old English modal.

M12.
Translate "The ship will be ready." Use the bēo-series indicative to describe the expected later state. Then contrast the earlier eom-series sentence "The ship is ready." Do not infer that every bēo-series occurrence must be future.

M13.
The "things" here are matters already discussed. Translate "I know those things. He knew those things." Use witan. Explain how this knowledge construction differs from cunnan followed by an infinitive.

Practice I. Complete command pairs and instructions

I1.
Give the second-person singular and plural imperatives of hīeran, nęrian and gefręmman. Label both numbers.

I2.
Give the second-person singular and plural imperatives of cyssan, gefyllan, sęttan, gierwan and sęllan. Label both numbers.

I3.
Give the second-person singular and plural imperatives of lufian, habban and libban. Label both numbers.

I4.
Give the second-person singular and plural imperatives of sęcgan and hycgan. Label both numbers.

I5.
Give the second-person singular and plural imperatives of drīfan, bēodan, bindan, helpan and drincan. Label both numbers.

I6.
Give the second-person singular and plural imperatives of wrēon and tēon. Label both numbers.

I7.
Give the second-person singular and plural imperatives of beran, niman and cuman. Label both numbers.

I8.
Give the second-person singular and plural imperatives of giefan, biddan, sittan, licgan and etan. Label both numbers.

I9.
Give the second-person singular and plural imperatives of sēon, slēan and fōn. Label both numbers.

I10.
Give the second-person singular and plural imperatives of hębban, scieppan and swęrian. Label both numbers.

I11.
Give the second-person singular and plural imperatives of faran, standan and healdan. Label both numbers.

I12.
Give the second-person singular and plural imperatives of weaxan, hātan and lǣtan. Label both numbers.

I13.
Give the second-person singular and plural imperatives of dōn, gān and both command series of wesan/bēon. Label both numbers.

I14.
Translate "Take the food and carry it." First address one person, then several. Identify what "it" refers to and preserve its grammatical gender.

I15.
Translate "Help me. Give me the water." First address one person, then exactly two people. Explain the verb number used for the two addressees.

I16.
Translate "Do not drink the water. Sit and eat." Address several people.

I17.
Translate "The man said: 'Go and do the work well.'" The man addresses one companion.

Practice N. Infinitives and purpose

N1.
Give the plain infinitive and the selected inflected infinitive after tō for bindan, beran and sęllan. Use the course's -anne forms where the table selects them.

N2.
Give the plain infinitive and the selected inflected infinitive after tō for hīeran, cyssan, nęrian, gefręmman and gierwan. Use the course's -anne forms where the table selects them.

N3.
Give the plain infinitive and the selected inflected infinitive after tō for lufian, habban, libban, sęcgan and hycgan. Use the course's -anne forms where the table selects them.

N4.
Give the plain infinitive and the selected inflected infinitive after tō for wrēon, tēon, sēon, slēan and fōn. Use the course's -anne forms where the table selects them.

N5.
Give the plain infinitive and the selected inflected infinitive after tō for gān, dōn and both wesan/bēon series. Use the course's -anne forms where the table selects them.

N6.
Translate "He wants to eat. He came to eat." Use the taught plain-infinitive complement in the first sentence and the taught purpose construction in the second.

N7.
Translate "The companions came to help the man." Use the inflected infinitive for their purpose. Identify the person doing the helping and the case of the person helped.

N8.
Translate "The man came to give food to the birds." Use the inflected infinitive for the purpose.

N9.
In Hīe sculon ðæt weorc dōn and Hīe cōmon tō dōnne ðæt weorc, identify each finite verb, each infinitive, and the construction that selects the infinitive form. Translate both sentences.

N10.
Complete the taught modal construction "We can carry the food" using mugan and beran. Then make the subject "I". Explain which verb changes for person and number.

6. Food and water for the journey

The following connected account is new teaching material. Read its statements and instructions together. A command requests an action; the later narrative reports what occurred.

> Se mann cwæð: ‘Ic wille faran. Mīn scip is gearu. Cumað and helpað mē.’ Twēgen gefēran cōmon tō helpanne. Se mann cwæð: ‘Nimað ðone męte and berað hine. Giefað ðǣm fuglum ðæt wæter.’ Se gefēra cwæð: ‘Ic mæg ðone męte beran. Wē sculon ðæt weorc gefręmman.’ Đā gefēran bǣron ðone męte and gēafon ðǣm fuglum ðæt wæter. Se mann cwæð: ‘Sittað and etað.’ Đā gefēran ǣton. Hīe fōron.

Practice C. The connected account

C1.
Read “Food and water for the journey”. Who asks for help, how many companions come, and what is their stated purpose? Answer in English.

C2.
List every imperative in the controlled text and give its addressee number. For each, give the singular command form taught in the tables.

C3.
In the controlled text, identify the antecedent and case of hine, the recipient of the water, and what the companions subsequently eat. Distinguish what is explicit from what the context suggests.

C4.
Identify wille, mæg and sculon in the controlled text by person, number, tense and stated sense. Give the infinitive governed by each.

C5.
Translate the whole controlled text. Preserve the distinctions among a wish to travel, ability to carry, obligation, commands and completed past actions.

C6.
Rewrite the man’s first quoted commands, Cumað and helpað mē, as commands to one companion. Separately, put the first sentence of the original narrative into the present, keeping its original quotation unchanged.

7. The fisherman's gift and first direction

Editorial context. Apollonius survived the earlier storm, encountered an old fisherman, and asked for help.

This excerpt continues with the fisherman's care and gift, ending after his first complete spoken direction. It is from Cook's Reader XII, **Apollonius**, printed p.167 / one-based PDF p.183, editorial prose lines 3–10. The edition has printed marginal anchors at 5 and 10; the intervening line numbers are editorial. The speech continues in the source. A closing quotation mark is added at this excerpt's boundary; the Old English wording and spellings are retained.

> Đā, sōna swā se fiscere geseah ðæt se geonga mann æt his fōtum læg, hē mid mildheortnesse hine ūpāhōf, and lǣdde hine mid him tō his hūse, and ðā ēstas him beforan lęgde ðe hē him tō bēodanne hæfde. Đā gīet hē wolde, be his mihte, māran ārfæstnesse him gecȳðan; tōslāt ðā his wǣfels on twā, and sealde Apollonie ðone healfan dǣl, ðus cweðende: "Nim ðæt ic ðē tō sęllanne hæbbe, and gā intō ðære ceastre."

Local help

These ten groups of help remain available during the reading exercises. Their unfamiliar forms and constructions are supplied for this passage; they are not independent-recall vocabulary or general construction patterns. The learned finite verbs, commands, and infinitive morphology can still be identified within the supported clauses.

1. Đā, sōna swā se fiscere geseah ðæt se geonga mann æt his fōtum læg,

Then, as soon as the fisherman saw that the young man was lying at his feet.

Đā means "then"; **sōna swā**, "as soon as." Fiscere is nominative singular, "fisherman"; geonga is the weak masculine nominative singular adjective, "young." The temporal clause contains the whole content clause introduced by ðæt, "that." Its finite verb læg means "lay; was lying." In æt his fōtum, "at his feet," fōtum is dative plural. The feet are the fisherman's. Both nested clause relations and the prepositional phrase are supplied as a whole.

2. hē mid mildheortnesse hine ūpāhōf,

He compassionately lifted him up.

Mid mildheortnesse, "with compassion," is a supplied manner phrase with dative mildheortnesse. **Ūpāhōf** means "lifted up": it is the supplied

third-singular preterite of a prefixed verb, not the unprefixed hębban form. Hē is the fisherman; hine is Apollonius.

3. and lædde hine mid him tō his hūse,

And led him with him to his house.

Mid him means "with him," here accompanying the fisherman. **Tō his hūse** means "to his house"; hūse is the supplied dative singular of hūs, "house." In this clause hine is Apollonius, while him and his refer contextually to the fisherman. The accompaniment and destination phrases are supplied locally. Tō before the noun phrase is distinct from tō before an inflected infinitive.

4. and ðā ēstas him beforan lęgde ðe hē him tō bēodanne hæfde.

And set before him the provisions that he had to offer him.

Ēstas is supplied masculine accusative plural, "provisions; food"; **lęgde** is a supplied third-singular preterite, "placed; set." **Him beforan** means "before him," with the dative person. The following **ðe** is an object-relative referring to the provisions: "that/which he had to offer him."

Here "had to offer" means **had available for offering**, not "was obliged to offer." Tō bēodanne has the learned inflected-infinitive form; bēodan's "offer" meaning is familiar. The whole availability construction, its relative clause, and its offered-object/recipient relation remain supplied. Both occurrences of him refer to Apollonius; the second is not a reflexive "himself."

5. Ðā gīet hē wolde, be his mihte, māran ārfæstnesse him gecȳðan;

He still wanted, according to his ability, to show him greater kindness.

Gīet means "still; further." **Be his mihte**, "according to his ability," contains dative singular mihte from the noun miht, "ability; power." It is not a modal verb here. **Ārfæstnesse** is accusative singular, "kindness"; māran agrees with it as the comparative "greater." **Gecȳðan** is a supplied plain infinitive, "show." In this exact use the thing shown is accusative and its recipient is dative him, Apollonius. The finite wolde expresses the fisherman's past desire. The prefixed verb and its local government are supplied, not a rule for forming new prefixed verbs.

6. tōslāt ðā his wǣfels on twā,

He then tore his cloak in two.

Tōslāt is the supplied third-singular preterite, "tore." **Wǣfels** is the accusative singular object, "cloak." The fisherman remains the subject

without a repeated pronoun. Keep **on twā**, "in two," as a whole supplied expression. Its usual analysis takes twā as neuter accusative, but that spelling also occurs in feminine forms; it does not identify an unexpressed noun or establish a general rule for motion with on.

7. and sealde Apollonie ðone healfan dǣl,

And gave Apollonius one half.

Apollonie is the supplied dative singular name, "to Apollonius." **Ðone healfan dǣl** means "one half," literally "the half part." Dǣl, "part," is accusative singular; healfan is the weak masculine accusative singular of healf, "half." This is the familiar giving construction with its recipient and thing given. No second object has to be added.

8. ðus cweðende:

Saying thus.

Ðus means "thus." **Cweðende**, "saying," is a supplied present participle accompanying the fisherman's action. It introduces his words without serving as a finite past or an imperative. Compare its role with the familiar finite cwæð; no productive participial construction is required here.

9. "Nim ðæt ic ðē tō sęllanne hæbbe,

Take what I have to give you.

Nim is a singular command. Supply the whole following phrase **ðæt ic ðē tō sęllanne hæbbe**, "what I have to give you." Here ðæt introduces a definite free relative, "what/that which"; it is not merely the article before an omitted noun in an independently learned rule.

"Have to give" again means **have available to give**, not obligation. The fisherman is ic; Apollonius is the dative recipient ðē. Sęllanne has the learned inflected-infinitive form. Hæbbe is read here as the familiar first-singular indicative, but its isolated spelling is also shared with subjunctive forms: the letters alone do not uniquely identify its mood. The whole relative and availability construction remains supplied.

10. and gā intō ðǣre ceastre."

And go into the town.

Gā is a singular command. **Intō ðǣre ceastre** is supplied as "into the town." Ceastre is dative singular, with matching feminine dative ðǣre. Preserve this actual phrase; the presence of motion does not justify changing it to an accusative or deriving a general rule for every destination. This completes the first spoken direction; do not add the continuation.

Source note. The excerpt is Cook Reader XII, p.167 / PDF p.183, editorial lines 3–10. The source has **læg** without a length mark and **gīet** with long ī. Line breaks are joined and the attached note cues are moved below. The final closing quotation mark marks the editorial stopping point; it is not printed there in the continuing speech.

Cook's original notes

The numbered references below are Cook's, not sections of this unit. The local help above supplies the needed interpretation.

P.167, note 5. fiscere: See 143.

P.167, note 6. ēstas: Lat. epulas.

P.167, note 7. ārfæstnesse: MS. fæstnesse. Lat. pietati.

Practice R. The original excerpt

Use all the printed local help. Identification of learned forms does not require independent recall of the supplied clauses.

R1.
Read "The fisherman's gift and first direction", using its local support. What prompts the fisherman's action, what does he divide, and what does he give Apollonius?

R2.
Find wolde and its plain infinitive in the source. Parse wolde and explain the fisherman's intention. Use the supplied meaning of gecȳðan.

R3.
Identify tō bēodanne and tō sęllanne. Give the familiar plain infinitive behind each. Explain the source's "have to offer/give" phrases using the printed support; do not translate them as modern English "must".

R4.
Find the source's two singular commands. Parse each and give its plural command form from the taught system.

R5.
Use the notes to distinguish the participial cweðende from the finite past cwæð and the command gā. Which form introduces the fisherman's actual words?

R6.
What does the fisherman say he has, and what first direction does he give? Explain the force of the phrase translated “what I have” using the local support.

R7.
Identify the source’s tō phrases that contain an inflected infinitive and distinguish them from tō his hūse and intō ðære ceastre. State the locally supplied meanings of the destination phrases without deriving a general motion-preposition rule.

R8.
Translate the whole 76-word source excerpt with its supports. Stop after the fisherman’s first direction; do not add the continuation of his speech.

8. Cumulative practice

Practice X. Combining the constructions

The final task admits more than one coherent answer. Keep to its lexical bank and the constructions taught here; the four sentences should form a connected account.

X1.
Translate “We two wanted to give our food to the birds. We two gave it to them.” Retain the two-person possessor and the grammatical gender of “food”.

X2.
Translate “The old man cannot carry the great ship. Help him.” Address several companions in the command.

X3.
Translate “He came to help us. We wanted to give him food. He sat and ate.” Use the taught elementary purpose and volitional constructions.

X4.
Compare the statement Gē gāð with the command Gāð. Explain the shared spelling and the difference in use. Then compare Hē dēð ðæt weorc with Dō ðæt weorc.

X5.

Write four connected Old English sentences about a man and two companions: one past arrival with an explicitly stated purpose, one statement of willingness, one direct command addressed to both companions, and one completed past action. Use cuman, helpan, willan and beran, with mann, gefēra and męte and any needed taught articles, numerals or pronouns. Label the three new constructions.

9. Sources and form choices

The core forms follow Albert S. Cook, **A First Book in Old English: Grammar, Reader, Notes, and Vocabulary**, second edition, revised and enlarged (Ginn, 1895). The compact tables explicitly identify the three persons covered by each shared plural row and apply the given endings to the selected stems. Such paradigm completion is not a claim that each cell is separately quoted in continuous prose.

Joseph Wright and Elizabeth Mary Wright, **Old English Grammar**, second edition (Oxford, 1914), corroborates the forms and variants; the precise witan and magan variant locators follow below. R. D. Fulk, **An Introductory Grammar of Old English with an Anthology of Readings**, author-corrected open-access reprint (2020), supplies the cited distinctions concerning defects, j-presents, the bēon series, and infinitival use. **Bosworth–Toller, An Anglo-Saxon Dictionary**, main dictionary (1898), supplies the individually cited lexical senses and constructions; page letters a and b identify columns.

All PDF page numbers in this unit are one-based. In the selected Cook scan the PDF page is printed page +16; in Wright, +20; in Fulk, +12. Dictionary facsimiles are cited by printed page and column rather than by an invented PDF position.

The examples and "Food and water for the journey" are new compositions. The original fisherman excerpt preserves its source wording, with only the declared closing quotation mark added. Its supplied nouns, participle, prepositions, and clause constructions remain local help. Earlier participles and other reference-only forms do not become command or infinitive systems through resemblance in spelling.

Local reading help. Compare Cook §§87a and 87d, pp.51–52 / PDF pp.67–68, for relatives; §164b, p.94 / PDF p.110, for offering and giving; and §§194–200, pp.104–106 / PDF pp.120–122, for the verbal forms and uses. The availability and relative phrases in the reading remain supplied as a whole.

The supplied lexical help follows the corresponding entries in Cook's **Vocabulary**, whose headword spellings are retained in these references: æt (p.274 / PDF p.290); ār-fæstnes (p.276 / PDF p.292); be (p.277 / PDF p.293); be-foran; bēodan (p.278 / PDF p.294); ceaster (p.281 / PDF p.297); dæl; cuman (p.282 / PDF p.298); ēst (p.285 / PDF p.301); fiscere (p.287 / PDF p.303); fōt (p.289 / PDF p.305); ge-cȳðan (p.291 / PDF p.307); geong (p.293 / PDF p.309); gīet (p.296 / PDF p.312); healf (p.298 / PDF p.314); hūs (p.300 / PDF p.316); in-tō (p.301 / PDF p.317); lęcgean (p.302 / PDF p.318); mid; miht; mild-heortnes (p.305 / PDF p.321); sōna (p.313 / PDF p.329); tō; tō-slītan (p.316 / PDF p.332); ðus (p.319 / PDF p.335); ūp-ā-hębban; wǣfels (p.320 / PDF p.336).

Witan variants. Wright, §540, printed p.283 / PDF p.303.

Magan variants. Wright, §§544–545, printed p.285 / PDF p.305.